

LAMENT FOR ALASTAIR DEARG. (Alastair Dhu? of Glengarry.)

THERE appears to be only two published versions of this tune in staff notation. that in "Ceol Mor" and the Piobaireachd Society's version. There is also a Canntaireachd version in Gesto's publication. The "Ceol Mor" version is consistent, in that the metre, 4:6.4, is found in the Variations as well as the Ground. The Piobaireachd Society's version, however, is open to criticism on the ground of its inconsistency alone, for it has 16 bars in the Ground (3:6.4 metre) and 18 bars in the variations (4:6.4 metre). The "Ceol Mor" version indicates that General Thomason has inserted his third Ground bar to obtain four bars in the First Part! The Piobaireachd Society omits General Thomason's third bar and thus leaves the part with three bars, which are repeated to form six, in the endeavour to make the metre of the Ground 6.6.4. Such a metre as 3:6.4. would not seem to be supported by any known cases and is, indeed, entirely contrary to the general principles of construction of a 6.6.4 metre tune. Our only hope, therefore, would seem to lie in Gesto's Canntaireachd version. This clearly indicates the First Part is *repeated*, and we are then fairly safe in assuming its real metre is 4:4.4. The Analysis on the opposite page, showing the two staff notation versions and also Gesto's version, will indicate that a very passable 4:4.4. metre tune is easily constructed from the Canntaireachd. The Canntaireachd, divided into bars and parts, is as follows:—

I. Hiembotrao, hioradin	hodro botrieo, hiodin	hodro,	dirro hiererin,	hiererin
Hiembotrie hiavirla	hiehaheha, hihahiha	hiehoheho, hachin hachin	hachin hachin, hihuhochin,	
Hie a ho, bitrio havi	hiea hovi, hiochin	hiochin, hiodin	hiererin.	hiererin

The Variations in the Canntaireachd version present some difficulty. Indeed, it is probable they are chiefly responsible for the attempts to render the tune as of 6.6.4. metre. Close study of these Variations, however, suggests some "overlapping," for it looks as if some player in the old days had commenced *doubling* his beats in the second part and then repeated himself in his endeavour to get back to regularity! This would seem the only explanation of 42 beats appearing in the 1st Variation, 41 in its Doubling and in the 2nd Variation and its Doubling (Beat No. 21 being omitted). The other Variations have 31 beats, the repetition of the first ten beats being omitted. Dealing with the 42 beats, therefore, it will be noticed the "Doubling" commences with Beat No. 23 and continues till Beat 29. The player then goes back to two beats per bar, and after playing No. 29 (E) goes back to F (No. 30), probably confusing his 29 (E) with 24, the same note! This doubling and overlapping produces six beats too many, leaving us with 36 beats. Deduct from this the two excess beats in Analysis Division 6 ($\times 2 = 4$ because repeated) and also the two excess beats in Division 19, we are left with 30 beats, the two missing ones belonging to Division 14 and the last half of Division 16.

Regarding the Ground, all versions agree the first bar of the part in Division 7. Now to make this a six barred part it would be difficult to go past Division 13 with any logic, even though, musically, the part seems unfinished. To produce a four barred part, however, Division 14 must be brought in, and the part closes, musically, with finish. The last part, to produce four bars, requires Division 18 from Gesto, and this is not unreasonable, seeing his first part closes the same way! Division 19, from Gesto, is clearly excess, in any case, as are his Variation beats in Divisions 6 and 19. The version given is from Gesto, with the Variation beats revised.

Gesto's version has a Siubhal (Dithis) and Doubling, Taorluth, Taorluth Mach, Crunluth and Crunluth Doubling. The form of Crunluth used in the Doubling is an *extended* beat and the only difference between the Singling and the Doubling being—

LAMENT FOR ALASTAIR DEARG. Analysis.

HISTORICAL NOTE.—It would be interesting to know if any real authority exists for the name "Alister Dearg" in connection with this tune! Gesto calls it "Allister Dhu of Glengarry, Esq." "Alister Dearg" died before 1645, probably about 1630, whereas "Allister Dhu" died in 1724, much lamented by his Clan. In the absence of real authority for connecting the tune with Alister Dearg, one is tempted to consider the Lament as for Alister Dhu, for its style is *not* suggestive of Patrick Mor MacCrimmon, who was probably entering his prime in 1630. It is more likely to be by one of the later composers, otherwise it would probably have "died a natural death" long ago!

Division No.1					2	3	4	5	6	
Ceol Mor.										
Piob: Society.										
Gesto.										
Variations—Ceol Mor and Piob: Society.										
Gesto.										
(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)		(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9) (10)	

Division No.7					8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19		
Ceol Mor.																		
Piob: Society.																		
Gesto.																		
Variations—Ceol Mor and Piob: Society.																		
Gesto.																		
(21)	(22)	(23)	(24)	(25)	(26)	(27)	(28)	(29)										
					(30)	(31)	(32)	(33)	(34)	(35)	(36)		(37)	(38)	(39)	(40)		
																(41) (42)		